GLASSHOUSE

JUST NOT CRICKET

Team India's loss in the ICC World Cup final on November 19 soon became a political debate on, of all things, *panautis* (bad omens). The match was held at the stadium in Ahmedabad named after Prime Minister **Narendra Modi,** who was the chief guest. On November 21, at an election rally in Rajasthan, Congress leader **Rahul Gandhi** took a dig at the PM, hinting that India may have lost because a *panauti* had reached the venue. In fact, since the loss, many social media handles linked to the Congress had been posting how India won two World Cups during the UPA regime and none since Modi came to power. Not to be outdone, BJP supporters pointed to the date itself as a *panauti* (it was the birth anniversary of the late PM Indira Gandhi). Just before the match, **Priyanka Gandhi** had reminded the nation that her grandmother had hosted the winning side of the 1983 World Cup for tea at her residence.

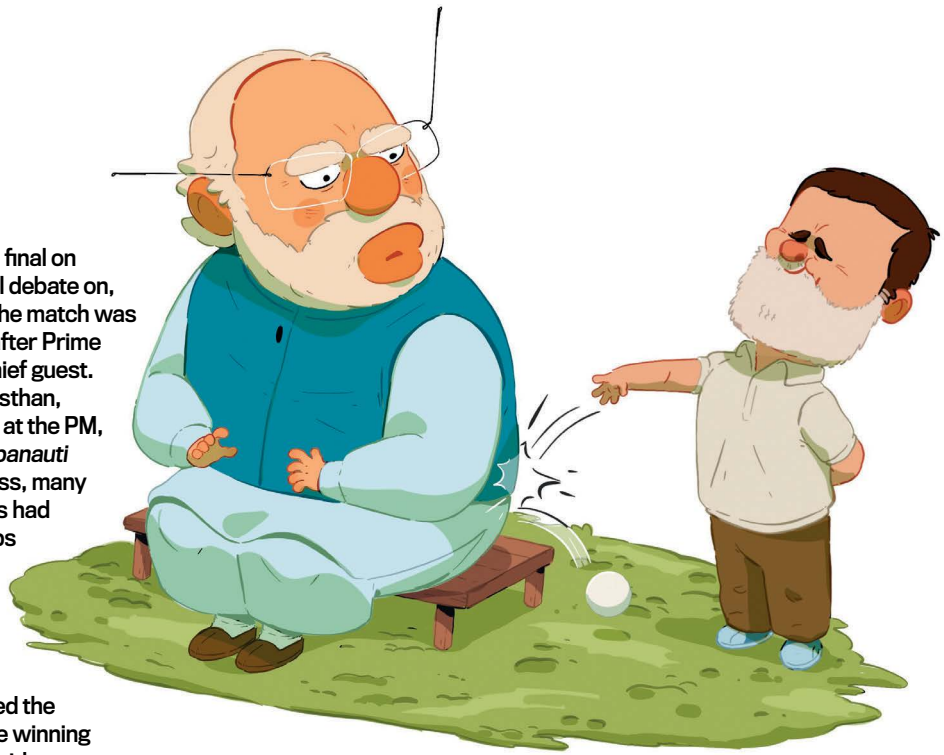


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

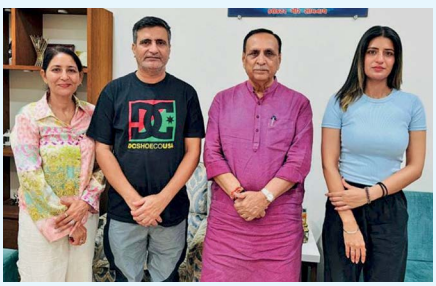


Fact-check

This was one journey that threatened to end before it began. Kerala chief minister **Pinarayi Vijayan** had launched a mass outreach programme, Nava Kerala Sadas, on November 18. The plan was for him and his ministers to go a month-long bus tour of the state. But the media was soon awash with stories of the bus's alleged luxury facilities "worth over a crore". This, when the state has reneged on some pension allocations for months, giving the Opposition a stick to beat the ruling party with. A frustrated Pinarayi eventually invited journalists to visit the bus and report about the facilities. A few media outlets expressed regret later. The damage, though, was already done.

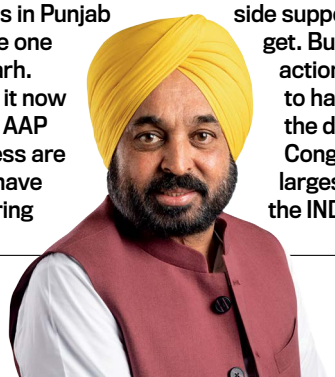
A Different Pitch

It was the day of the World Cup final, and former Gujarat chief minister **Vijay Rupani** was posting pictures of his meeting with **Shubman Gill's** parents at his Gandhinagar home on social media. Why Rupani and not any other neta, everyone wondered. The grapevine has it that Gill's father harbours political ambitions...and the BJP leader is in charge of Punjab, their home state.



BURNING BRIDGES

The Lok Sabha election is less than six months away, but the the opposition INDIA bloc has yet to get its act together. On November 19, Punjab chief minister **Bhagwant Mann** claimed that the Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) would contest all 13 Lok Sabha seats in Punjab and the lone one in Chandigarh. After Delhi, it now seems that AAP and Congress are unlikely to have a seat-sharing alliance in Punjab too. The alliance partners are at loggerheads in Punjab, with Mann's vigilance bureau going after Congress leaders. With the Enforcement Directorate tightening the noose, Delhi CM and AAP supremo Arvind Kejriwal could do with the outside support he can get. But Mann's actions seem to have shut the door on the Congress, the largest party in the INDIA bloc.



HARDIK CHHABRA

Bulb Moment



Tamil Nadu finance, planning and electricity minister **Thangam Thennarasu** was addressing the 70th Cooperative Week celebrations in Tirunvelveli on November 16 when the lights went out. Resuming his address later, Thennarasu pointed out that the media had got 'breaking news' from the event—a power cut when the electricity minister was speaking. "I was searching for a topic when the lights went out," he said cheekily before going on to counter the charge of power-tripping in the state.

Kaushik Deka with ***Anilesh S. Mahajan, Jumana Shah, Jeemon Jacob and Amarnath K. Menon***